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cadre. Meanwhile, department enquiries are on to see if disciplinary action needs to be taken against Wankhede.

The *Cordelia* fallout has led to the speeding up of reforms that were under way in the NCB. Pradhan has issued strict instructions to his team to not go after consumers but focus on cracking down on the big drug cartels, both national and international. As he puts it, "We found that our investment in investigating one gram of charas and one tonne of it is about the same—so I have told them to concentrate on the big fish." Earlier, Pradhan had requested the government to beef up his staff from its current strength of 1,200 to 3,000. That would give him enough men to take on the gigantic task of curbing drug trafficking that has turned particularly serious with the Afghanistan cartel back in business. India is now both a major market and a transit country for illicit drugs.

The other big concern is the growing rate of addiction in the country. A recent survey commissioned by the Union ministry of social justice and empowerment reveals that there

SUSHANT, RHEA AND AN ABETMENT

After the Narcotics Control Bureau's botched up investigation into the Aryan Khan case, another high-profile case that Sameer Wankhede handled—actor Sushant Singh Rajput's alleged suicide in June 2020—has come under the scanner. The NCB had filed a 12,000-page chargesheet against Rajput's girlfriend and actor Rhea Chakraborty and 32 others, including her brother Showik and Agisilaos Demetriades, in March 2021. Demetriades is the brother-in-law of actor Arjun Rampal. The trial is yet to begin.

The NCB claims a packet of marijuana was delivered to Chakraborty's residence in Santa Cruz in November 2019 for Sushant and claims she is a member of a drug syndicate as she allegedly paid for it, delivered it to him and facilitated its consumption. Chakraborty's lawyer Satish Maneshinde rubbishes the NCB's claim, and says the agency's efforts are to somehow "implicate my client in a case". "The entire amount of 'narcotic substances' recovered from these 33 accused is nothing compared to what even a constable in Mumbai police would recover from a street raid," he says.

Both Rhea and Showik are out on bail but spent 28 days in jail in September 2021. On June 1, the NDPS court allowed her to travel abroad to Abu Dhabi for an awards show, but she finally didn't go as a look-out notice is still out on her. In her application before the court, the actor stated that she has incurred significant setbacks to her career as well as financial losses because of the criminal prosecution and the resultant media trial.

The CBI (Central Bureau of Investigation) also investigated whether Rajput's death was suicide or murder. It looked into Rhea's role and also whether Sushant had transferred Rs 15 crore to her account, as claimed by his family. The agency completed its probe in December 2021 but, six months on, is yet to submit its findings. ■

–Kiran D. Tare